

Boundary Work and Strategies of Compliance: The Underlife of the Ivory Tower

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Abstract

This study examines strategies employed by university administrators and managers to gain compliance from subordinates even as they attempted to increase their workload. These strategies have received comparatively little attention within organizational studies of compliance. The participants in our study included employees at a public university in the Midwest identifying themselves as either “staff/faculty” or “managers/administrators.” Our findings indicate that when administrators and managers are unable to use formal rewards and punishments they attempt to gain compliance from subordinates through two main strategies that we identify as *overtures* and *interactional trebuchet*. Both strategies represent a sequence of interaction that we refer to more generally as “boundary work”—a set of activities through which boundaries on time, resources, and workload are defended or diminished, and for which we provide a model. We draw upon organizational, symbolic interactionist, and dramaturgical theories in the analysis of our data.

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Introduction

Sociologists of all theoretical stripes have attended to the ways in which relations of power are both created and socially reproduced as well as challenged (Althusser [1970] 2008; Hall 1985, 1997; Hallett 2003; Poulantzas 1975; Prus 1999; Schwalbe et al. 2000). Notable scholarship has pointed out that the exercise of power, whereby people are pressed into compliance, is necessarily tethered to practices of legitimation (Habermas and McCarthy 1975; Wolf 1990). Reviewing Weber's analysis of authority, Hall (1985) cogently observed that legitimation is foremost an interactional achievement as forms of dominance come to be collectively defined as beneficial for group life. When stripped of this collective definition, dominance is experienced as nothing more than control—control of language and thought, control of criteria upon which evaluation occurs, and control of the rules along with a system of monitoring, ensuring their enforcement. Significantly, “dominance also gives the controlling actor the ability to develop the forms of deference and demeanor, control of space and time, and paradoxically, greater freedom to vary from the rule” (Hall 1985, 316). But what happens when formal means of control are lacking, when subordinates protect themselves, their space, their resources, and their time by collectively organizing or simply refusing to obey?

In assessing power within complex organizations, sociologists have looked at the ways in which worker consent and compliance are both secured and contested. Studies of this process have ranged from focusing on the ways in which (1) the culture of workers reproduces power relations in work organizations (Burawoy 1979); (2) highly technical language in work produces relationships of dependency on workers (Vaughan 1990); (3) corporate managers exercise control over workers (Bies and Tripp 1998; Kunda 2006); and (4) how both management and workers seek tactical advantage as labor relations become conflictual (Fantasia 1989; Morrill, Zald, and Rao 2003). Concurrent with these studies is extensive research in the field of communication looking at the variety and use of “compliance strategies” among managers and others (Buchholz and Knorre 2023; Grant, King, and Behnke 1994; Kellermann and Cole 1994; Kipnis et al. 1984; Riccillo and Trenholm 1983; Wilson 2002). In the article that follows, we seek to extend the analysis of power in organizations by assessing the tactical repertoire managers use in

breaking down walls of resistance posed by subordinates when the formal means of gaining worker compliance are untenable, unsuccessful, and/or legally actionable. We refer to this repertoire, *in toto*, as *boundary work*. Presented in a variety of interactionist works, we have re-defined and broadened the concept for our own purposes. In the analysis that follows, we present qualitative data gathered from administrators, staff, and faculty at a moderately sized university in the upper Midwest, observing the interaction strategies used by institutional managers with their subordinates.

Methodology

In collecting data for the study, we developed a survey for university officials (administrators and managers) featuring open-ended questions. We asked respondents about how they gained compliance from subordinates even as a budget deficit removed the formal rewards upon which they formerly relied. Likewise, we developed a survey asking their subordinates (faculty and staff) to describe their experiences with administrators. Specifically, we inquired about the tactics used by administrators in efforts persuading them to take on tasks above and beyond their normal workload. In both surveys, we asked respondents about forms of ingratiation that organizational participants at all levels of the university commonly identify as “brownnosing.”

We first administered the survey to an IRB-approved pilot group that included respondents at various universities in the Midwest. As no subsequent changes were made to the instrument, the data collected in the small pilot study are included in our analysis. The surveys were administered via e-mail to potential respondents employed at “Midwest University” (“MU”),¹ a regional public university in the upper Midwest whose Human Subjects Institutional Review Board approved our study.² While the sex ratio of our total sample was balanced, its ethnic composition reflected the broader university setting in which the data were gathered, with the majority of respondents identifying as White (see Table 1).

The total number of questionnaires returned to us by faculty and staff ($n=80$) paled in comparison to the total number we sent out ($n=550$)—a response rate of less than 15%. By contrast, the response rate among managers/administrators ($n=30$) was 56%. While we were concerned with issues of selection bias, we did not find the low response rates among faculty and staff surprising. It may certainly be the case that only respondents with an axe to grind may comprise most of our respondents—including faculty and staff exceedingly angry with administrative decisions as well as administrators and managers feeling compelled to defend their decisions, their legitimacy as office holders, and their collective identity as fair and

Table 1. Composition of Faculty and Administrator Samples.

Staff & Faculty				Managers & Administrators		
Race	Female	Male	Total	Female	Male	Total
White	35	31	66	13	14	27
Black	1	0	1	0	0	0
Native American	0	1	1	1	1	2
Asian	2	1	3	0	0	0
Other	2	4	6	0	1	1
Total	40	37	77	14	16	30
Missing ³			3			
Grand Total			80			30

impartial university administrators. In a classic essay on feminist methodology, Devault (1990) assessed the problem of interpreting silence during her interviews with women. We would argue that her cogent insights can be extended to a variety of workers within the academy. Indeed, we were left wondering if the subordinates in our sample who refused to participate did so fearing retribution from their superiors. We thought it just as likely, however, that subordinates’ failure to participate was due to feeling overworked, alienated, uninterested, and angry at being asked to carry out yet another institutional evaluation, or simply nonplussed.

Following the prescriptions of grounded theory for “ethnographic content analysis” (Altheide 1987) we each open-coded the qualitative data independent of one another, interrogating and coding responses written by our participants, line by line. Throughout the analysis, we searched for themes emerging from the narratives, accounts, and descriptions provided by our informants, relying upon the “constant, comparative method” that is at the heart of grounded theory (Charmaz 2014; Glaser and Strauss 1967; Strauss and Corbin 1990). Following our independent analysis, we compared our coding of the textual data discovering an intercoder reliability of over 92%. Consistent with the qualitative approach we previously used in analyzing similar forms of organizational language (Martin and Wilson 2011, 2012), we sought to develop conceptual categories—theorizing the meanings, strategies, and activities of respondents as they negotiated their daily work context.

The narratives and accounts provided us by workers and managers revealed the *idiocultures* (Fine 1987, 1996) of both groups whose respective work contexts intersected even as their organizational interests and subjective experiences significantly differed. Our research was guided by

three broad questions as we strove to understand the ways in which administrators manufactured consent: First, what is the range and nature of managerial strategies when formal rewards and punishments for ensuring subordinates' compliance no longer exist? Second, under what conditions are these options viable, used, and/or discarded? And, finally, how do workers interpret and respond to these strategies?

In attempting to answer these questions, we solicited responses from salaried employees hired to supervise other paid workers within the university system. We refer to this group as a whole as *managers*.⁴ We use this label generically to provide cover for the top administrators, as well as staff supervising only one or two other people, whose identities would not otherwise remain anonymous because of their small numbers.⁵ The other group of respondents was comprised of faculty and staff who supervised no other *paid* employees even though faculty obviously supervise students. The narrative data gathered through the qualitative surveys allowed us to better understand this particular organizational culture, giving special attention to the interaction strategies and vocabularies of motives commonly employed by managers/administrators. Importantly, the data enabled us to interrogate how these strategies and vocabularies of motives are described by both administrators and staff/faculty. Additionally, we were able to understand the subjective experiences of workers in this context.

The Structural Conditions of Managing

For most university systems within the United States, the period known as the “great recession” (2007–2013) produced challenges for administrators as they sought to balance budgets, hire new faculty and staff, and financially support students with declining revenues from state legislatures. These challenges persisted even after the recession was proclaimed as having ended (Bernstein and Spielberg 2016). The organizational context within which we conducted our research was no different as managers sought solutions to remedy a multimillion-dollar deficit. The organizational, personal, and interpersonal stress experienced by managers was palpable as they assessed the viability of a variety of institutional strategies for keeping the university financially afloat. The ideas most commonly discussed—terminating staff, implementing a hiring freeze, and consolidating departments and work units—were all strategies placing restrictions on organizational resources while increasing demands on the time and responsibilities of lower organizational participants. Threats of “workload increases” were met by staff and faculty who advanced claims that “administrative bloat” was driving the budget deficit. At several campus meetings, faculty admonished administrators

to implement cuts at the highest managerial levels before cutting educational programs. In the days that followed, administrators reduced the number of service staff members and adjunct faculty, while asking full-time faculty members to take on added responsibilities for teaching and public relations work. Foremost among these was a request for outreach to high schools, civic organizations, and constituents who might serve as recruitment pools and potential funding sources. In some college units, faculty were expected by top managers to lead task forces for accreditation and were consequently blamed for the failure of program reviews when they invoked the union contract—a contract protecting them from unauthorized and unremunerated increases in their workload. The pattern of task assignment, credit for success, and blame for failure found in the accounts of faculty, generally approximated that discussed by Jackall (1988). In his study of managerial work, Jackall's (1988) observations within a tech firm revealed that while top managers might initially conjure up a new idea for a project, the actual responsibilities for developing a plan, attending to the details, and resolving emergent technical problems were pushed down onto their subordinates. Consequently, blame for project failure was placed on workers, while credit for a project's success was appropriated by top managers. In contrast to Jackall's study, staff and faculty at MU began to file grievances with their respective unions over issues of wage and time theft and increase in their workloads. The issues were alleged by both groups to have violated work agreements established in their current labor contracts. As institutional managers cut positions to resolve a budget crisis, a strategic plan to push the work of former employees onto those remaining was devised. Faculty would be asked to teach more classes and assume responsibilities for public relations with donors and constituents while still maintaining high levels of research. The plan was advanced even as faculty salary increases were postponed.⁶ Bound by stipulations in the labor contract, as well as constrained by their own administrative philosophy granting autonomy and input from faculty, administrators were left with few legal, organizational options for gaining worker compliance with their plan.

Boundary Work

In using the term, *boundary work*, we refer to the work that individuals and/or groups do to create, maintain, reestablish, transcend, or mitigate boundaries so that personal and organizational resources may more easily be guarded or acquired. Situated in an array of different studies under a variety of tropes, the idea of boundary maintenance has been deployed in a number of areas, including the analysis of children's gender boundaries (Thorne 1993); managerial control over how and where high-tech workers spend their time (Perlow

1998) as well as how tech workers draw project boundaries (Maaninen-Olsson and Mahring 2009); and how middle-level managers draw upon vocabularies of change in shifting job responsibilities (Oldenhof, Stoopendaal, and Putters 2016). We use the concept more generally in identifying a process of interaction involving managers and workers. Although this process can take a variety of forms, we find that work boundaries in most organizations are commonly maintained in accordance with job descriptions. Through boundary work both managers and workers may seek to mitigate as well as reify the formal expectations of office—increasing or defending their resources, workload, and the time demanded of them and/or their associates.

In the analysis that follows we lay out a grounded theory of this process, wherein university managers rely upon two different strategies for securing compliance from subordinates that we refer to more generally as *overtures* and *interactional trebuchet*. As episodes of interaction, we investigate this process, beginning in the phase of conversation known as the “opening” and concluding in workers’ responses to one of five different tactical moves made by managers.

Openings

Boundary work is initiated by what Schegloff (1968) referred to as an “Opening,” that is, the first phase in a conversational sequence. Analyzing conversations between police dispatchers and callers who sought help or notified police of crimes in process, openings in most conversations are, Schegloff pointed out, “nonterminal.” That is, openings such as salutations are commonly used to introduce topics that will be developed in further conversation. In the conversations initiated by university managers requesting faculty and staff to take on tasks that would increase their workload, openings commonly served as attempts to precondition their responses. Respondents in our study generally identified openings in conversations where people told stories, interacted for sheer enjoyment, or told “little white lies,” under the single rubric “bullshitting.” Similarly, in previous research, a student participant reported: “Bullshitting will be helpful because I think it makes a person a little more sociable and it helps people relate to one another.” (Martin and Wilson 2011: 1258). Others noted its use in enhancing the credibility of both one’s claim and oneself: “. . .bullshitting is needed in order to get [to] where you want [to be]. . . You want to make yourself seem . . . special and the whole package. So, you bullshit part of it.” (Martin and Wilson 2011: 1255). As a process of social lubrication enabling a future demand or claim, openings were commonly marked by levels of sociality on the part of managers that were seen as unusual. In light of such performances, subordinates in the

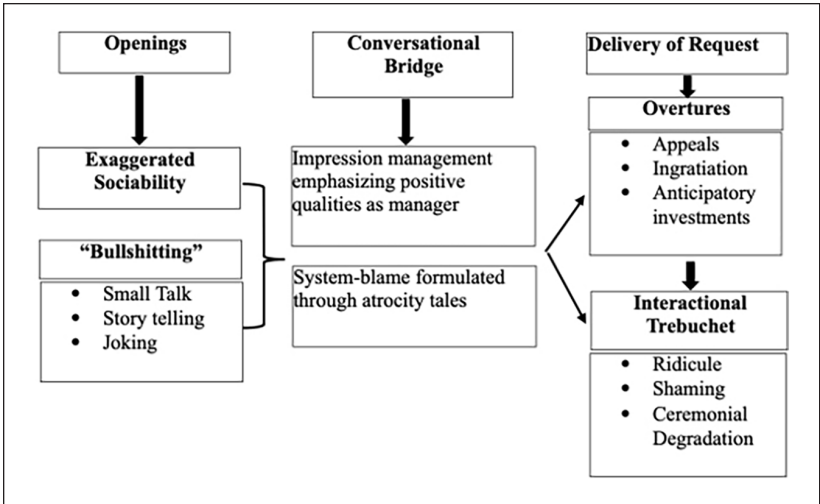


Figure 1. The Micro-Structure of Boundary Work.

interaction often sensed that they were being “battered up” in advance of a future request. Managers, as well, cited interactions initiated by subordinates bearing this quality as a process they anticipated would include a request they were not officially required to grant. In this context, openings are conversational devices communicating both emotion as well as narrative content, designed to establish or renew social ties between people engaged in a mutual reading of the interaction at hand. The general contours of this process have been presented below (see Figure 1). Goffman (1971) suggested that such interactions commonly include symbols and interaction rituals displaying a mutually recognized social relationship, referring to such symbols as “tie signs.”

Just as joking behavior between people does not necessarily mean a joking relationship exists, the appearance of tie signs in interaction does not necessarily mean that a preestablished relationship is reciprocally regarded or invested with the same degree of significance. In previous research on ingratiation (Martin and Wilson 2012), participants’ stories of “brown nosing” included tales of interaction within the workplace strategically designed to deceive others into believing that they were held in high regard even while treating them as unwitting dupes. Commonly, openings initiated by managers in the MU workplace were used, as one respondent explained, to “get people on my side” before making a request to increase their workload. The conversational bridge to such a request was usually a

statement attaching blame to those higher in the system—including vice chancellors, presidents, board members, or state legislators—for the conditions making such requests necessary. System-blame accounts commonly included a personal testimony as to how the manager was attempting to shield the work-unit from budget cuts. In an encounter where friendly salutations led to the unfolding of a request, conversational bridges constituted phases in interaction when frame alignment by managers might soften the path to compliance on the part of subordinates. Borrowed from Goffman (1974), frame alignment has remained a central concept in the analysis of social movement scholars, explaining how the messaging of organizers and activists gains resonance with sympathetic bystanders and other possible participants (Gamson 1982; Snow et al. 1986). In negotiating the relations with subordinates, frame alignment is accomplished in the construction, appropriation, and alteration of meanings that resonate with subordinates, disarming any resistance that forthcoming requests might meet. The delivery of requests anticipated to draw resistance commonly assumed one of two forms: those that were designed to maintain or at least minimize damage to the relationship with subordinates (*overtures*) and those requests indicating subordinates would be penalized for non-compliance (*interactional trebuchet*), constituting a structure of relations identified by Gouldner (1954) as “punishment centered bureaucracy.”

Overtures

In conventional discourse, the term “overture” refers to “an approach or proposal made to someone with the aim of opening negotiations or establishing a relationship” (OED 2009). For our purposes, the use of the term here denotes a similar meaning—the introduction of a topic that will be developed in further discussion with the intent of enhancing the relationship, creating a hospitable context within which a request will be made. Organizationally, overtures are specifically designed to assuage concerns surrounding requests by virtue of feelings of trust and goodwill that emanate from the encounters between managers and their subordinates—irrespective of which party makes the request for resources, favors, or exemptions to which they might not otherwise be officially entitled. Overtures, themselves, ultimately culminate in requests. Commonly woven together with a variety of interaction strategies on the part of supplicants, overtures are designed to maximize their acceptance by the party who, for all practical purposes, need not otherwise grant it. As our grounded theoretical approach empirically revealed, these strategies foremost included appeals, ingratiation and, to a much lesser extent, the making of “anticipatory investments.”

A Taxonomy of Appeals

As a general strategy for preconditioning the acceptance of a request, overtures are filled with a variety of appeals—earnest pleas that exhort action on the part of the listener usually with only a minimal promise of reciprocity. We analyze the general contours of the most commonly used appeals below.

Moral Appeals

Foremost among appeals are those that managers' hope will resonate with the experience of subordinates because of their virtuous import:

Datum from manager: I have appealed to their moral values and personal experiences to sway their behavior . . . I have an employee that is respectful but not always kind to the students they encounter. Being kind isn't a job requirement, but I feel it is an important part of creating a welcoming atmosphere for our students. I use every opportunity to draw a parallel between [our] students and the employees' grown children and school-aged grandchildren, because I can't imagine my employee is unkind to their own family members. It doesn't always work but I feel it is my best option.

Above, the manager refers to the use of a moral appeal in which they specifically invoke the image of family, hoping to modify the brusque style of interaction that a faculty member has with students. As with the use of other types of appeals, administrators must do guesswork in assessing the type of person(s) with whom they are dealing. Here, the assumption is made that the faculty is a loving family member as the administrator attempts to frame the meaning of interaction with students in familial terms, hoping the imagery resonates.

While all appeals are *suasive* in nature, rhetorically crafted to achieve compliance on the part of subordinates through personal influence, they vary in the emotional content they contain. Arguably, emotion is a key ingredient in creating "referent power"—that is, the influence of a person or group as others take their perspective in evaluating themselves (Raven 1990, 502). However, not all appeals rely upon the use of emotion or weave moral imperatives into the dialogue at hand.

Appeals to Reason

In contrast to managers who used moral appeals in attempting to convince workers to assume a greater workload, some managers at MU attempted to exert influence through logic and rationality. In making *appeals to reason*, a couple of managers remarked:

Datum 1: I'm afraid the only tool I use is reason and evidence. That may mean that some of my requests are not complied with.

Datum 2: I've never had anybody resist my request. A discussion of the merits for the work takes place and the potential benefits to the Institute and community as a whole are noted.

As the statements above reveal, managers construct appeals hoping that the "facts" alone will convince subordinates to cede to their request. However, observations must be interpreted, and those interpretations consensually validated to be considered "facts." Administrative logic suggesting that an increase in subordinates' workloads is rational may in fact be tenuous, challenged by an alternative set of facts, or simply regarded with suspicion by underlings.

Appeals to the Common Good

One of the most common appeals crafted by managers was a statement tethering a request for service to the idea that the entire group—department, college, university—was counting on subordinates to "step up to the plate." For example, in talking about recruiting faculty for committee work, one manager revealed: "I typically use the idea that we are a 'team' and have to each make contributions to the good of the department—which includes serving on both college-wide and university-wide committees." Appeals to the common good were easily knitted together with claims that subordinates alone possessed an area or level of expertise which set them apart, singling them out as the only candidate for the job who could carry out the task. To the degree that such claims exceeded faculty's own evaluation of the skills they possessed, or were made with unjustifiable fervor, they lost resonance. When aligned with workers' own interests, the appeals proved effective. One faculty member commented:

I am a tenured faculty member. In two separate years during the decade following the year 2000, it was requested by my department head that I teach an extra course for no extra pay (because of budget limitations), in order to maintain the viability of our program. I agreed because maintaining the program was of utmost importance to me and to our students. This was not reflected in the merit distributions at the end of those two years.

Appeals to the common good were sometimes made in public contexts—such as department meetings—and thus could be crafted to bring into play the evaluative power of the viewing audience. Acting in a singular voice, this

audience could either reinforce the positive sentiments crafted to flatter the faculty member being issued a call for service or witness a presumed compatriot refusing to help out colleagues in a time of need. Such a strategy holds much in common with Sykes and Matza's (1957) technique of neutralization, "appeals to higher loyalties." Both the managers asking workers to do more for the good of the group and workers agreeing to go above and beyond their typical job requirements could be seen as employing this technique in justifying their behavior.

Emphasized within appeals to the common good were themes that were foundational for maintaining group life within a department, a college, or the university as a whole—namely, claims for loyalty and calls for help. Claims of loyalty made upon subordinates are only effective to the degree that department chairs, deans, and upper administration prove worthy of such fealty. One of the key paradoxes for upper management was how to garner that loyalty when the material means for doing so were lacking and mismanagement was seen—at least in part—as the cause of the budget deficit. Reciprocally, faculty members' claims that administrators lacked loyalty to programs prized by faculty could be easily buttressed by an accounting of the programs and faculty positions cut because of the budget deficit. While objections by administrators might be raised, recognition of impending budget cuts also meant that the options for solving "structural problems" were limited.

Appeals to Tradition

At times, managers appealed to tradition in an effort to persuade subordinates to comply with their requests for additional service and increased workloads. In light of such sacrifices, not only is the claim made that "this is how it's always been done," but managers also typically make reference to how departments, units, and individuals have achieved a vast array of programmatic and personal successes in the past by complying with these pragmatic requests. For example, one manager noted: "We have a history of career growth in our department. That often happens because people are willing to take on work and challenges outside their normal duties." Another statement from a manager highlights the tradition in their department of employees being "team players"—that is, those who are "more than willing to take on extra tasks and make sacrifices for the betterment of the department and to aid their co-workers." It is perhaps unsurprising that appeals to tradition, then, are intimately interwoven with appeals to legitimacy.

Appeals to Legitimacy

Consistent with the emphasis on tradition and teamwork are appeals more generally to the legitimacy of requests made by both managers and their subordinates. In part, this speaks to the credibility that is created through one's role performance. As one manager stated: "I just explained why I was asking the person to do what I was asking. If you have the respect of your subordinate, most of the time this should be enough." Woven into such appeals are accounts highlighting both the substantive and organizational rationality of action.⁷ One such example is committee assignment presumed legitimate by virtue of the nature of the committee and the tradition of turn-taking. In the words of one manager:

We rotate the department representative for a committee and when it came time for a subordinate to take their turn I noted that the position rotates and it was simply his turn. I also noted that the committee is not overly taxing and we all have service as a part of our job.

Similarly, in describing their approach in requesting that faculty members step up for particular tasks, a manager explained:

I've never had anybody resist my request. A discussion of the merits for the work takes place and the potential benefits to the institute and community as a whole are noted. I usually discuss openly the reason for the request and why it needs to be done. I'll ask why the person is resistant to wanting to do it and try to come to some common ground over getting it done.

Both managers and workers are well aware of the multitude of demands attendant their positions within the academy. It is mutually acknowledged that the nature of work does not follow a set 9:00 a.m. to 5:00 p.m. schedule. Recent surveys show that, at all ranks of professorship, faculty commonly work an average of sixty-one hours per week.⁸ Furthermore, academicians have typically put a great deal of time, effort, and dedication into their teaching and research pursuits. This can readily be used to justify exploiting faculty members' labor. One of our faculty respondents referred to this as a function of the "passion economy"—that is, "when workers are also pursuing something they are 'passionate' about, recognition [e.g., being praised by a superior] in whatever form can create an opening to taking on a task or tasks that is not in any way required." Social relations governed by rules and expectations that are not only mutually agreed upon but also reinforced by both administrators and faculty are the hallmark of work contexts identified by Gouldner (1954) as a "representative bureaucracy." Within such contexts,

administrative appeals for an increase in workload may commonly be made and accepted in their banality with little or no resistance.

Supplication Appeals

A key self-presentation strategy identified by Goffman (1959) was supplication—that is, appearing helpless and/or lacking in the competency required in a particular situation so as to gain the assistance of others. This strategy was observable in instances where managers lacked the ability, competence, or time to complete their job responsibilities . . . and could not legally shift this work onto subordinates. Additionally, the number of PhDs on campus (over 500), made it likely that expertise and assistance could readily be found among faculty. In one instance, managers concluded that projections of (decreasing) student enrollments in light of a huge budget deficit meant that university programs would have to be cut. Unable to manage the large-scale task of assessing the cost/benefit of each and every university program, supplication appeals by managers to faculty in the business school were made. As one manager explained, “I’m just not good with numbers.”

It is not surprising that the process of supplication is commonly accompanied by attempts at ingratiation on the part of both managers and workers. Ingratiation is considered a micropolitical resource used by subordinates for accruing favors and/or resources from superiors. In extensive research on “intraorganizational influence tactics,” Kipnis, Schmidt, and Wilkinson (1980) found that it is managers and supervisors rather than subordinates who routinely engage in ingratiating behaviors. This finding is supported within our study by data suggesting that the key condition under which brownnosing flows downward in the organizational structure is when administrators can neither officially sanction subordinates nor offer formal rewards. In such instances, managers turn to informal, interpersonal, symbolic rewards—including effusive praise and flattery—to gain compliance. We refer to this dynamic as *sucking down*, discussing it more fully in the section that follows.

Sucking Down

Ingratiation is commonly initiated as actors, through their performances, weave together a variety of accounts into their presentations of self. Some managers openly admitted to brownnosing subordinates, attempting to persuade them to take on tasks. Likewise, a number of their subordinates provided examples of being targets of such attempts. Other managers acknowledged that they gave their subordinates compliments, but maintained

that they were being genuine and that their compliments were empowering for workers. This differential assessment of communication between managers and their subordinates is evident in the data provided below. Workers responding to our query about ingratiation readily revealed numerous instances on the part of their superiors. One faculty member, commenting on recurrent requests from a top administrator to chair university committees, remarked: "My former department head praised my program evaluation skills as a way to get me to agree to work with a program on campus for free and without any research product (i.e., without any professional benefit to me)." Other workers provided similar accounts:

Datum from faculty member: I am often approached to do work over and beyond others and am told that no one else is good or able to do it. I sort of know that it is bull, but also want merit pay and I want to feel praised, so I go along with it. Later, I usually feel bad.

Datum from faculty member: I get this myself all the time. It is a way to manipulate me into doing service projects by telling me that I am so much better than everyone else.

Datum from faculty member: This happens to me a lot. I am always told how good I am, how organized, etc. to take on yet another task. I am embarrassed to say that it is effective.

Datum from faculty member: I have been praised for my capacity to fulfill difficult administrative tasks and then asked to continue to do more. I have been praised for my expertise and then asked to use my expertise for my department and college.

Two themes appeared common in the accounts of workers as they described ingratiating encounters with the administrators. When used, ingratiation was almost always followed by a request on the part of administrators to increase a faculty's workload, and ingratiation was experienced as a form of manipulation to get workers to do something for which they would not otherwise volunteer. As an interaction strategy, ingratiation was also observable in the accounts provided by managers who eschewed the label, "brownnosing," but acknowledged a singular objective:

I did this when inviting faculty to serve on a Budget Advisory Group for our college. When sending the email invitation out to the pertinent faculty members, I included the following phrasing at the end of the email: 'I hope you'll be willing to serve in this important role for the college. I'm inviting you to be a member of the budget advisory group because I know you are a thoughtful and conscientious person who can be mindful of the best overall interests of the college and its academic units.'

In trying to get faculty to volunteer for work that was time-intensive, managers became acutely aware of constraints imposed by the labor contract. In contrast to workers, however, they offered a significantly different evaluation:

Datum from manager: I've sometimes been in situations where I've talked with faculty or staff members about their strengths, and I've referred to these strengths when inviting them to take on a task or a leadership role. I wouldn't regard this as brown-nosing because I was describing actual strengths and I wasn't embellishing or simply trying to curry their favor.

Datum from manager: [I] encouraged employee to take a special project on in which they could exercise their own skills in the area needed; employee successfully completed task and was able to highlight their skill which normally is not called for in their current capacity. Employee felt empowered, and successful.

In instances where workers identified managers' communication as brown-nosing, managers regarded their flattery as genuine, citing it as an example of their authenticity. Some workers ceded the existence of institutional and community needs requiring work that extended beyond the typical parameters of one's job. This is a reality with which they are familiar and are sympathetic toward. For example, a worker noted :

Someone has to do it. Your community needs it. You have the skills. There is no reward available, except for your good feeling that you will have done something for your community, and the praise. The praise is an advance, your satisfaction (and someone's 'thank you') is the balance payment. I have lived all my life on these premises.

Another worker shared this observation:

Department head and/or dean use flattery and praise to ask a faculty member to take on another task. Basically they only have positive reinforcement techniques to get jobs done, and most faculty members already have more than a 100% job.

That managers may have few if any good options in compelling people to take on additional tasks was mutually acknowledged by at least some workers. Reporting the tactical choices they made in gaining subordinates' compliance, all of the managers in our study indicated that they made requests using tactics that we have identified more broadly under the rubric, *Overtures*. Questions in our survey concerning the use of punishment to gain worker

compliance yielded significant differences between administrators and faculty in particular. In contrast to the proportion of university administrators (0%) reporting the use of negative sanctions with subordinates, 20% of faculty reported having been the targets of such action. In the following section, we explore the forms and dynamics of this action.

Interactional Trebuchet

We use the term *interactional trebuchet* in reference to interaction initiated as a symbolic, frontal assault in an effort to either break down walls of resistance to work requests—such as those for resources such as time, money, technology—or to halt such requests. In lieu of termination of employment, the use of public ridicule, open threats, defamation and debasement of character directed at individuals, and/or entire groups in an effort to gain their compliance may serve as a form of “soft repression” (Ferree 2005). Feminist scholars have used the concept in explaining how women fomenting resistance to processes of subordination have been silenced even as inequality in everyday life is reproduced (Ferree 2004; Schwalbe et al. 2000).

The Use of Threats

Data from workers in our sample likewise noted the significance of threats from managers in silencing individuals posing resistance. In some cases, the threat was far-reaching, resulting in workers feeling uncertain about the future and well-being of their students, programs, and departments. During the course of our data collection, workers shared numerous examples:

Datum 1: Retribution or punishment was implied for failing to acquiesce to the desires of a dean in a search/hiring decision. The form of retribution was not directly implied but became clear later [the faculty member was informally told that they would not be considered for leadership positions as a result].

Datum 2: My previous department [chair] was always threatening to give me 8 AM classes to teach if I didn't do whatever task [they] wanted done or if I complained about something. [They] never did assign me early classes but [they] held it over me.

Datum 3: I was threatened by a former department head who wanted me to teach a class for which I had no training or expertise. The department head made it an issue in my annual review and, even after being told by the dean that the dean did not want me to teach the class (the dean wanted me to concentrate on my research) and did not want the

department head complaining about it in the review, the department head continued to pester me about it.

Datum 4: My previous department head long ago indicated I needed to write questions for [their] educational venture (for profit). I only did it in a less than perfect way to avoid the negative repercussions of not going along. Those negative repercussions were potentially not supporting my promotion or pay raises based on my lack of enthusiasm for [their] venture.

Datum 5: On multiple occasions [the dean would give] thinly veiled threats that if a faculty member doesn't toe the line ([their] line, not something that is officially a policy), then they or their program will be in jeopardy (e.g., not renewed).

Datum 6: The [administrator] threatened . . . closing the department if faculty refused to get involved with evaluation and report writing for an upcoming accreditation visit. The [administrator] had mismanaged the college and overlooked a deadline for the initial report and then blamed faculty for [their] mistake. When faculty responded negatively to [their] false accusation, [they] proceeded to threaten jobs, initiated moving people out of their offices and into smaller spaces, and looked for ways to degrade their professional identities and status. Many of my colleagues came to hate [the administrator].

Because relations of power are organizationally situated, a variety of forms of talk—praise, criticism, encouragement, humor, and ingratiation—may be differentially defined depending upon: the organizational location of actors initiating and receiving them; the nature of the relationship between them; and the social context in which communication takes place. Thus, the vocabulary managers draw upon in securing compliance from subordinates may create the appearance of an organizationally rational decision for an audience of other managers and top administrators even as workers consider the communication a threat. For example, the statement “We may have to eliminate *the* entire department” may seem entirely logical when shared with fellow administrators. When communicated to disgruntled employees who have voiced opposition, implicating the perceived incompetence of their supervisor, the same statement may readily be translated by those workers as “Do this or I am getting rid of you.”

Shame and Degradation

In a classic ethnomethodological analysis—*Conditions of Successful Degradation Ceremonies*—Harold Garfinkel (1956) theorized the relations

between perpetrators, denouncers, and observers in shaming rituals designed to degrade the social status of individuals before an audience of others. Situated in a context within which a “blame worthy” event occurs, degradation ceremonies are “successful” to the degree that denouncing agents are able to tie the perpetrator to the event and transform the perpetrator’s identity. According to Garfinkel, the key transformation is that the perpetrator comes to be seen as an “outsider” by the observing audience. Such dynamics, while absent in the data presented above, were not unknown among faculty in our study, some of whom had been the recipients of such treatment. Yet, organizational managers, themselves, were not immune to becoming targets of such action. Both faculty as well as administrators were aware that a well-established ceremony—known as the *vote of no confidence*—was a tactic previously implemented by faculty. The tactic was readily accessible should administrators be considered woefully incompetent or unbearably punitive in their roles. While the use of this ritual was rare, it appeared from our data that shaming was an ever-present threat in the experience of some faculty and staff:

Datum from worker: Our department head will point out what “subordinates” are doing to shame others into agreeing to do those tasks as well. Often, we will get handouts in our mailboxes telling us who has volunteered for certain tasks . . . and who has not.

Datum from worker: We have a smaller faculty number relative to many departments and are overburdened by service. Each year, our department head approaches us with a list of committees [they’d] like us to serve on, and when we voice concern regarding role overload and overextension, [they] say, “well, other faculty in other departments are sitting on this committee,” or, “so-and-so is already on one committee that requires a lot of work, so you could do these three that are less labor intensive.”

Datum from worker: Several male superiors (and even some female superiors) frequently say things like, “well, (you) are still plotting your pathway as an academic and could use this experience as a form of mentoring.”

While the data presented above indicates the sensitivity of workers to strategies that lower one’s sense of self-worth, successful degradation ceremonies require the actual co-presence of others to ratify the “degrading claims.” Public venues by their very nature constitute such contexts. In department or committee meetings, requests made by superiors of their subordinates may be strategically framed and timed to maximize the anticipated

evaluation of some audience. Workers in this study reported that failure to comply with the wishes of their superior was followed by an unexpected criticism designed to diminish them. The following was shared by one faculty member who stated:

Our Dean had provided our research committee with very little information on how we should distribute research and travel money to faculty. The committee agreed that we would use the merit of the research project. Because the Dean's [favored] candidate was not on the list [they] accused our entire committee of being racist and not understanding the nature of the work [of this particular candidate]. One-third of the committee were people of color; another third were themselves working on issues pertaining to racial and social justice. The last third contained some of the most respected people in the college.

As a form of social action, shaming is designed to highlight the failure of an individual to live up to the standards of a community (Lynd 1958; Piers and Singer 1953): "shame does not exist apart from the scorn of others, expressed or imagined" . . . "others are related to oneself as an audience" (Kurtz 1982, 66). Of course, whether attempts at shaming are used in public or in private conversations, such claims made may be avowed, strategically minimized, staunchly contested (Martin 2000). . . and/or met with "secondary adaptations" (Goffman 1961).⁹ At most, ritualized forms of shaming and degradation—such as faculty arbitrarily being moved into smaller offices by their Dean—may temporarily stall resistance by subordinates but only fan its flames in the long run. For the administrators trying to resolve a budget crisis by utilizing such tactics, the question of how to gain compliance from a highly trained, disenchanted, and increasingly hostile workforce remained.

Conclusion

The goal of our study has been to explore what sociologist Erving Goffman (1961, 171) identified as the "underlife of a public institution" by looking at the ways in which an academic context both shapes and is shaped by interaction designed to gain compliance from subordinates. By limiting our focus to the forms that such strategic interaction takes we have excluded from consideration other important concerns already receiving much more attention by other scholars: namely, how race-ethnicity, gender, class, and status characteristics of interlocutors might shape interaction within organizations.¹⁰ For example, studies on gender and communication have consistently demonstrated a relationship between traditional, masculine identities and the use of more authoritative and/or coercive means of persuasion (Drass 1986; Smith-Lovin and Brody 1989; Zimmer 1987). While this dynamic certainly deserves

attention in light of newly emerging “trans” identities, the strategies for compliance that we observed were not restricted in their use to managers exhibiting any particular demographic characteristics.

Neither has the scope of our study included investigation into factors commonly identified as “self-selection,” explaining how the psychological make-up of some managers predisposes them toward authoritarian practices while others lean toward approaches that are more inclusive and democratic. As sociologists attune to the social relations of work, we find it significant that structural conditions within which managers and their subordinates encounter each other may shape but do not determine the strategic choices they make as they engage in boundary work. Such choices are ongoingly negotiated in interaction between actors as each define the situation, define each other, and define their own tactical options. The process is complex, fluid, and filled with nuance not necessarily recognized in traditional organizational theory.

Power-dependence models suggest that the irreplaceability of subordinates affords them more power in decision-making.¹¹ One might expect that the power and influence of highly trained individuals such as university faculty with PhDs is enhanced where they, even as subordinates, possess technical or esoteric knowledge that others do not have. However, according to our findings this very dynamic may also lead to more claims on their time and intellectual resources by administrators not less. Moreover, changing work environments that introduce new technologies, new tasks, and/or reduce the number of people that can handle them (e.g., because of down-sizing due to budget cuts) may exacerbate the problem though in ways that are paradoxical and cannot be predicted.¹² We find it both reasonable and probable that most managers within the academy truly desire harmonious relations with their subordinates. Our findings on the kinds of overtures made by administrators to faculty seem to indicate exactly that. When managers within the academy have few material rewards to dispense, they may negotiate future rewards to be received at a later point in time. Such negotiated futures are, of course, a matter of trust and may be made beyond an official labor contract. When material resources do exist but are minimal, administrators may dispense them, making an *anticipatory investment*. That is, resources such as travel money, a temporary leave, or reduced committee work may be given to subordinates making such a request, with managers fully expecting reciprocity in the form of an increased teaching load, increased committee work, or future service on specific projects.

While this study is focused on a particular work setting—that of the university—it is reasonable to suggest that many of the dynamics described by our participants share much in common with workers and managers in other places of employment. Especially in work contexts where material rewards

are lacking (e.g., low wages, few benefits), it would seem that managers must rely upon a number of informal strategies to ensure compliance on the part of their subordinates. We suspect that our study has only plied loose information on compliance strategies at one level of strategic interaction within the academy. We invite more research into the highest levels of the ivory tower typically hidden from public view—research we anticipate will be both important and informative. We also encourage comparative studies examining the tactical repertoires of workers and managers across work contexts. While these will inevitably have commonalities, they may also may reveal novel tactics worthy of further investigation.

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Notes

1. No names of participants are used in this article, to ensure anonymity. Likewise, the name of the institution is a pseudonym.
2. IRB number for this study is 1605E88185.
3. The term, "Missing," designates open-ended questionnaires that were submitted by our participants but were incomplete in varying degrees.
4. We adopted this classification from Wright (1985).
5. We sympathize entirely with at least one of our reviewers who desired more specific information regarding the respondents we quoted. The primary convention that we used throughout the paper in the presentation of the data was to replace names and demographic identifiers with the simple name, "Data." A disagreement between the authors on this issue was resolved by both of us acknowledging that sample sizes were so small we simply could not guarantee the anonymity we promised to respondents had we included any further information beyond

- their organizational location in the university. Even then, we suspect that there will be some accurate if unconfirmed guessing as to some of the respondents supplying quotes throughout the article.
6. Faculty frequently pointed out in the course of labor negotiations that their salaries consistently lagged behind the university's peer institutions.
 7. See Stephen Kalberg's (1980) excellent exegesis of Weber's discussion: Kalberg, Stephen. 1980. Max Weber's Types of Rationality: Cornerstones for the Analysis of Rationalization Processes in History. *American Journal of Sociology* 85 (5): 1145–1179.
 8. See Colleen Flaherty, "So Much to Do, So Little Time." Inside Higher Education, Accessed April 08, 2014, from <https://www.insidehighered.com/news/2014/04/09/research-shows-professors-work-long-hours-and-spend-much-day-meetings>
 9. Goffman (1961) uses the term "secondary adaptations" in identifying those strategies that mental patients use in maintaining a sense of identity and self-worth in the face of the "stripping process" found within total institutions such as the military, prisons or mental hospitals. For example, the use of identity-stripping and degradation ceremonies that lowers one's social status and sense of self-worth may be resisted where inmates—as well as faculty we might add—can utter the words, sotto voce, "screw you" to a shaming overseer.
 10. For dynamics of race in organizations see Moss and Tilly (1996), Collins (1997), and Vallas (2003). For other research on gender dynamics in Organizations see Popielarz (1999), Haveman and Beresford (2015) and Zimmer (1987). For research on class and presentations of self, see Granfield's (1991) classic piece on working class students at an elite law school.
 11. See Pfeffer's (1981) notable work on the conditions facilitating the acquisition of power within organizations.
 12. During the COVID pandemic, faculty were told they must create lectures and course material in digital formats because of the chance that classes held in classrooms might become "super spreaders." Drops in enrollments were attributed, in part, to students' unwillingness to take classes "on-line." Both faculty and staff members pivoted, by necessity, to doing their work fully online. Faculty were then ordered back into the classroom when administrators assessed the move to have "acceptable risks." Likewise, staff were instructed to return to campus. A great number of faculty and staff preferred a hybrid model, whereby they would work from home certain days of the week. Yet, although the university touted their support of flexible work schedules, in many cases managers did not approve of faculty and staff exercising such flexibility.

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